

HR Interview Questions

1. Tell me about yourself.

ANSWER:: They want you to tell them (in your own words) a bit more about your background, work experience, attitude and ambitions. Make your

ANSWER: brief and to the point. Do not talk about your hobbies, personal likes or dislikes. Finish the ANSWER: by focusing on your Unique Selling Proposition, do this by mentioning what you are good at etc.

ANSWER:

I'm a experienced Sales Manager who has worked in the marketing industry for over 10 years. I have a successful track record of setting targets, developing sales teams and then motivating and training these teams to achieve goals.

2: How much is the salary you are expecting?

ANSWER:: I'm looking for a job and a company to call home. The most important thing to me will be the job itself and the company. If I am the right person for you, I'm sure you'll make a fair offer appropriate to my job responsibilities, experience, and ability to do the job successfully. May I ask what figure you have in mind or perhaps the salary range for this position?

3: Why do you want to work here?

ANSWER:: I am not looking for just another paycheck. I enjoy my work and I am proud of my profession .I believe (name the company you are applying for) has superior service and reputation. I share the values that make this possible, which should enable me to fit in and complement the team. I believe that the company can provide me with a stable and happy working environment. I think that your company has that reputation and that such an atmosphere would encourage my best work. (Please make sure that you have read the company's profile before you ANSWER: this)

4: What did you dislike about your last job?

ANSWER:: I really liked everything about the job. The reason I left is to find a position where I can makea greater contribution and a greater intellectual challenge.

5: What do you think of your last boss?

ANSWER:: I liked him/her as a person (if applicable), respected him/her professionally and appreciated his/her guidance.

6: Were there things that your supervisor did that you disliked?

ANSWER:: I have never thought of our relationship in terms of like or dislike. I have always thought our role was to get along together and get the job done. We had a very good relationship as far as I can remember.

7: Can you take instructions and criticism - without feeling hurt or upset?

ANSWER:: Yes, I can take instructions and more importantly, I can take constructive criticism without feeling hurt. Even with the best intent, I will still make mistakes and at times someone will have to put me back on the right track. I know that if I expect to rise in the company, I must first prove myself to be manageable.

8: How do you take directions? How do you handle criticism?

ANSWER:: I take directions well and I believe that there are two types: carefully explained directions when my boss has time, and then there's the other, a brusque order or correction. While most people get upset with the latter, personally, I always believe the manager is troubled with bigger problems and a tight schedule. As such, I take the direction and get on with the job without taking offense so my boss can get on with his/her job as well. It's the only way to accomplish our tasks.

9: What is your greatest strength? What do you consider your outstanding qualities?

ANSWER:s: Perhaps my greatest strength is the ability to stick to a difficult task yet be able to change course rapidly when required. I believe in planning and proper management of my time and yet I can still work under pressure.

10: What is the most difficult situation you have faced?

ANSWER:: (Give an example which is specific to your case; what follows is an example) Perhaps one of the most difficult decisions is to fire someone but I would like to emphasize that once I had examined the problem and reached a

conclusion, I acted in a timely and professional manner, with the best interests of the company at heart.

11: Are you willing to take calculated risks when necessary?

ANSWER:: Naturally, I would never take a risk that will in any way jeopardize the safety or reputation of the company or colleagues. In fact, I don't think any employer would appreciate an employee at any level taking risks of any nature without first receiving a thorough briefing and a chance to give input.

12: Rate yourself on a scale of 1 to 10, 10 being the highest.

ANSWER:: Perhaps an 8 or 9, as I always give my best shot, but in doing so, I always increase my skills and therefore always see room for improvement .

13: What have you learned from the jobs you have held?

ANSWER:: More than anything, I have learned that what is good for the company is also good for me. So, I listen very carefully to directions and always keep my superiors informed of my actions.

14: What do you think are your biggest accomplishments?

ANSWER:: Although I feel my biggest achievements are still ahead of me, I am proud of my involvement with (mention the job or project you are most proud of and how you contributed to accomplishing as its goals). I made my contribution as part of that team and learned a lot in the process. We all did it with hard work, concentration, and an eye on the bottom line.

15: How long would you stay with our company?

ANSWER:: I take directions well and love to learn. As long as I am growing professionally, there is no reason for me to make a move. How long do you need me to be of use there?

16: Can you work under pressure?

ANSWER:: Yes, I usually find it stimulating. However, I believe in planning and proper time management to reduce panic deadlines within my area of responsibility.

17: How do you handle tension?

ANSWER:: Tension is caused when you let things pile up. It is usually caused by letting other areas of responsibility slip by for a period of time. I find that if you break those overwhelming tasks into little pieces, they aren't so overwhelming anymore. So I suppose, I handle tension by handling the causes of it, by not letting things slip in other areas that can give rise to it.

18: What interests you most about this job?

ANSWER:: Before I ANSWER:, could I ask you to describe a typical day for me? I am looking for a challenge and an opportunity to being a team player and an opportunity to make a contribution.

19: Describe a situation in which your work or idea was criticized.

ANSWER:: I listened carefully and resisted the temptation to interrupt or defend myself. Then I verified what I heard to be sure my facts were straight. I asked for advice, we bounced some ideas around, then came back later and re-presented the idea in a more viable format. My supervisor's input was invaluable.

20: Why should I hire you?

ANSWER:: I believe I have the qualifications that you need; I am a team player; and I take directions and have the desire to reach success.

21: What can you do for us that no one else can do? Why do you feel you are a better candidate than others?

ANSWER:: I can bring to this job a determination to see projects through to a proper conclusion. I listen and take directions well. I am analytical and don't jump to conclusions. And finally, I understand we are in business to make a profit, so I also keep an eye on cost and return.

22: What kind of people do you find it difficult to work with?

ANSWER:: People who have a blatant disregard for others and do not follow procedures or are slackers -the occasional rotten apples who don't really care about the quality of their work. They are long on complaints but short on solutions.

23: (follow-up to the previous question) How will you handle these people?

ANSWER:: I would stick to my guns, stay enthusiastic, and hope some of it will rub off. If no amount of good effort on my part solves the problem, I will still maintain cordial relations. Life is too short to be affected by people who always think their cup is half empty.

24:What are your strengths?

(You should have already mentioned your main strengths and weaknesses in your CV or cover letter. To ANSWER: any questions like this simply go over what you have written in your resume. However always be prepared to back up any ANSWER:s you give with an example. Try not to appear big headed or someone with an inflated ego. Add a bit of modesty to any ANSWER:s you give.)

ANSWER:s:

I have been told that i am honest, reliable and ethical.

Your sense of urgency, if you know that a task is important, then you will work hard to get it done on time.

You are a fast learner.

Ability to communicate with people.

Flexible enough to handle changing environments.

Able to cope with setback and learn from my mistakes.

25:What are your weaknesses?

Mention that you have a flaw, but then also add a suggestion of improving that flaw or demonstrate any actions you are taking to address any weakness. The key to ANSWER:ing questions like this is to show you have learnt from your mistakes and are taking concrete steps to address it.

ANSWER:s:

Occasionally I have been told that I take longer than other colleagues to complete complicated projects or tasks. But this is only because I want to make sure the work I do is to the highest standards.

My MS PowerPoint skills are weak, so I have enrolled on a evening course to improve them.

I am sometimes accused of being over friendly.

What NOT to say:

You are a workaholic.

26:Why did you leave your last job?

The golden rule here is never to criticize any previous employers.

ANSWER:s:

There was no real room for growing my career.

The position you are advertising seems like a excellent match for my knowledge, abilities and qualifications.

I am looking for a job that has more responsibility.

The reason for leaving my last job was that I wanted to spend more time with my family. I am now ready to go back into full time employment.

27:Why do you want to work for our company?

This is essentially the same question as 'Why did you apply for this job?' & 'Why do you want to work here?'. Reply to it by showing that you have researched the employer and have logically thought out reasons why you think you are a good match for their requirements. Turn the ANSWER: into a compliment to the company you are interviewing for.

ANSWER:s:

There are only a limited number of opportunities for advancement with my current employer. Which is why I'm keen on working for a larger corporation like yours where I believe there are more possibilities to show what I'm capable of.

A common way to reply to this is to research the company before hand, find something unique about them and then give that as your ANSWER:. For instance they may have opened up a new store or launched a new product.

Give examples of positive things you have heard about them and say you want to be associated with a reputable brand.

You believe their work environment is more fun, energetic and rewarding.

I believe your company will help me to develop my career in the direction I want it to go.

28:What do your work colleagues think of you?

Be positive but do not go over the top. For instance comment on how associates have in the past remarked on your friendly attitude, thoroughness and ability to get things done on time.

Do you have any questions you would like to ask me?

You are likely to get this question thrown at you towards the end of the interview.

ANSWER:s:

What do you believe are the biggest challenges your company faces in the near future?

29:Can you tell me what brought you to work for the company, (this question is aimed at the interviewer).

What do you believe are the coming trends in your industry and how do you feel your company is positioned to take them on.

Following on from our conversation today and my belief that I am a suitable candidate for your position. If my application is successful when do you think I would be required to start work? (ask this right at the end).

30:Tell me about a problem you have solved.

This can be a tricky question to ANSWER:, especially if you have never held a supervisory/ managerial position or had any form of responsibility. In your

replies you need to display resourcefulness, an ability to solve problems, your decision making skills and be able to clearly explain the approach you used. No matter how little work experience you have you should always be able to lead and come up with creative solutions. Describe situations where you came up with an idea that increased efficiency in your office or cut costs after you discovered a cheaper supplier etc.

31:Where do you see yourself in say four years' time?

This is also the same question as 'Where do you want to be in 4 years?' The recruiter does not want to know about your personal goals i.e. you want a house in the south of France etc. They are only interested in your career ambitions. Try not to sound too ambitious, for instance saying you want to have been promoted to the head of your department. This can scare off some interviewers who may think your after their job! Instead sound ambitious but realistic.

ANSWER:s

In four years time I aim to have improved my abilities and to be a leader in my field. This will mean that I can contribute more to my employers and their business. That really depends on how well I perform in my job and also what career opportunities come my way. However the bottom line is that I want to have improved my skill sets and be making a ongoing contribution to any organization that i happen to be working for.

32:What is the biggest mistake you have ever made?

There is no danger in admitting to making a mistake. However to correctly

ANSWER: this type of query there are certain guidelines that you should follow. Firstly always mention that you identified where you went wrong and have learnt from the experience. Secondly try to give a example of something that happened as far back in your past as possible. This way you can shrug it off as a youthful error and something you would not fall for now that you are more mature and experienced.

ANSWER:s:

If I had a time machines I would go back to University and taken a degree in Business Studies rather than Hospitality.

I stayed too many years in a job that was stable but didn't offer me enough challenges or opportunities for growth.

33:How would you cope with a difficult colleague?

ANSWER:s:

This really depends on what my co-worker is doing, the severity of their actions and the specific problems or disruption that they may be causing. Having said that no matter what the situation is, I would always remain in control of any situation and concentrate on my work. I would not take any arguments or heated discussions personally or hold grudges against work colleagues.

I would avoid them and only talk to them or cooperate with them when required to in the course of my daily duties.

34:What do you like about your present job?

Try to link what you 'like' to any of the requirements of the job you are applying for. Also keep in mind that you are looking to leave your present jobs so don't make a big list.

ANSWER:s:

It provides me with constant new challenges to test my abilities.

Communicating and meeting with new people.

Able to use your initiative.

Working as part of a team.

35:What do you dislike about your present job?

Remember not to directly criticize or be negative about the company, managers or supervisors. Instead find other general issues to focus on.

ANSWER:s:

Sometimes it is difficult for me to get a sense of my own achievement in a big company like my present employer.

There are very few opportunities for advancement with my present employer who are a small company.

What NOT to mention:

Overtime issues.

Salary expectations.

36:You've changed jobs five times in the past five years, why should we think you are likely to stay here for a long time?

This is the same as asking why have you changed jobs so frequently? It is likely to be asked if your curriculum vitae shows that not held down a long term position but have regularly jumped from one job to another. When

ANSWER:ing you have no real option but to lump all your previous employers together. At all costs avoid showing that you are a difficult personality to get along with or that you have a habit of leaving jobs abruptly. ANSWER:s:

I do not believe that my career history is an accurate reflection of my character or abilities. Stability is important to me and I am anxious to work long term for one company. Although my CV shows that I have worked for a five different companies over a short period of time, the reason for this was that I had a elderly and frail relative to look after during this period.

Say that previous job roles failed to challenge you.

State that you current desire is to find long term employment and then give a reason for this i.e. your recently bought a house, just got married or are in a new committed long term relationship etc.

Mention and highlight any jobs you have held for long periods.

Point out the duties in the job you are applying for and state that these are the challenges you have been looking for.

37:What do you do outside of work?

If possible highlight interests and hobbies that are related to the role you are applying for. Talk about any foreign languages you know or exotic places you have visited. Also give examples of activities that portray you as a responsible, sociable person who has a friendly personality and who can get along within a team. These type of responses will help set you apart from other candidates.

ANSWER:s:

Travelling.

Foreign languages.

Football.

Winning any competitions i.e. chess, karate.

Running marathons.

A member of any societies or charities.

38:What's your current salary?

Questions about your current compensation may sound personal, but they can still be asked at interviews. Never lie or stretch the truth, as if you are found out it could jeopardize your entire application.

ANSWER:s:

My present employer pays me well outside of the norm, however I would not like to limit my job prospects by using that salary as a comparison.

As a highly valued member of the company, I am paid on the very high end of current market rates.

39:What do you enjoy about the industry you are in?

This can be a tough question that will put you on the spot. When responding be polite. diplomatic and give a good business related ANSWER:.

ANSWER:s:

I can't really give you a accurate ANSWER: because at this time I don't know the scope of the job, it's responsibilities, hours, etc.

The job I perform, the salary I receive and the circumstances at my current company are not really comparable to the opportunity we are discussing today. However when I consider my skill sets, academic qualifications and work experience, I am confident that a salary between £25,000 - £33,000 would be appropriate.

40:How do you stay updated with the latest industry trends and technologies?

ANSWER:: I subscribe to industry newsletters, attend webinars, and participate in online forums. I also follow influential industry leaders on social media and read relevant books.

41: How do you approach debugging a difficult problem?

ANSWER:: I start by replicating the issue, then use logging and debugging tools to trace the problem. I analyze the logs, isolate the affected code, and systematically test potential fixes until the issue is resolved.

42:Why do you think you're a good fit for this role?

ANSWER:: My background in [specific field], combined with my skills in [specific skills], align well with the requirements of this role. Additionally, my proactive approach and passion for [industry] make me a strong fit for your team.

43:What is your ideal work environment?

ANSWER:: I thrive in a collaborative environment where open communication and creativity are encouraged. A place with a strong team spirit, opportunities for continuous learning, and a healthy work-life balance is ideal for me.

44:How do you adapt to changes in the workplace?

Sample ANSWER:: I stay flexible and open-minded, viewing changes as opportunities for growth. I seek to understand the reasons behind changes, adapt my work habits as needed, and support my colleagues in adjusting.

45:What attracted you to our company?

ANSWER:: I'm impressed by your company's innovative approach and commitment to sustainability. The positive employee reviews and

opportunities for professional growth make it an ideal place for me to contribute and develop my career.

46: How do you handle conflicts within your team?

ANSWER:: I address conflicts early by facilitating open discussions, allowing each party to voice their concerns. I mediate to find common ground and work towards a solution that respects everyone's viewpoints.

47: How do you motivate your team during challenging projects?

ANSWER:: I ensure the team understands the project's importance and their role in it. I set achievable milestones, recognize individual contributions, and maintain a positive and supportive environment to keep morale high.

48: How do you handle situations where you have to analyze large amounts of information?

ANSWER:: I break the data into smaller chunks, categorize it, and use tools like Excel or SQL for analysis. I look for patterns, trends, and outliers to draw meaningful insights and make informed decisions.

49: Describe how you would manage a project with tight deadlines and limited resources.

ANSWER:: I'd start by clearly defining the project scope and priorities. I'd break the project into smaller tasks, delegate efficiently, and set realistic milestones. Regular check-ins and a focus on high-impact activities would ensure we stay on track.

50: How would you handle a client who is unhappy with your work?

ANSWER:: I'd listen to their concerns without interrupting, empathize with their situation, and take responsibility for any mistakes. I'd then propose a solution and work diligently to rectify the issue to restore their satisfaction.